

AXONA

A programmer's introduction

Self-authenticating, geo-aware pub/sub that runs in a browser tab — with no platform in the middle.

June 2026 · v0.2 · a ~30-minute talk

Live: demo.axona.net/apps/axona-minimal · Docs: github.com/axona-net/axona-docs

You'll leave with a working mental model of the network, the small API you actually call, and an app you watched run live — **Axona Minimal**, about sixty lines, publishing and subscribing over the real mesh.

What Axona is

- **A peer-to-peer pub/sub bus.**

Any peer publishes to a topic; any peer subscribes; messages flow peer-to-peer over an encrypted WebRTC mesh. No broker in the path.

- **Self-authenticating.**

A peer's identity *is* its keypair, and its address is derived from its public key and verified directly. No account, no certificate authority, no registrar.

- **It runs in a browser tab.**

Pure JS/WASM; the same kernel runs in Node and in the simulator. The cost of entry is a keypair and a page.

THE SHIFT

A hosted broker — Pusher, Ably, a Kafka cluster — is a company you trust and a switch someone can flip.

Axona moves that function *into the participants*. Nothing to sign up for, nothing to revoke through, and no chokepoint to censor or seize.

LIVE NOW

The first version is in the wild; anyone can connect.

Addresses are places

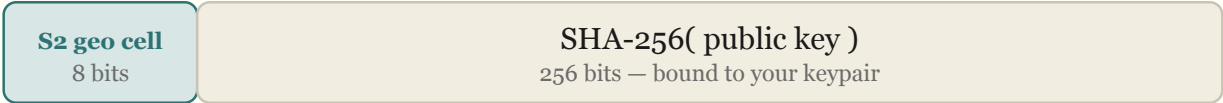
- Every id is 264 bits.

The top 8 bits are an S2 geographic cell; the rest is SHA-256 of the public key. Topic ids are built the same way.

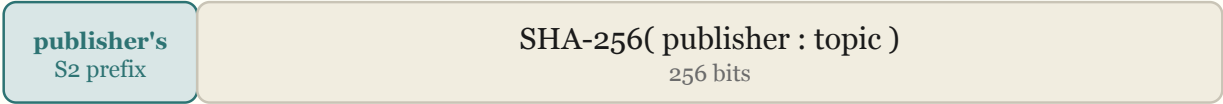
- Closeness is XOR distance.

The top byte dominates, so routing favors locality — without fencing anyone out.

node id — 264 bits

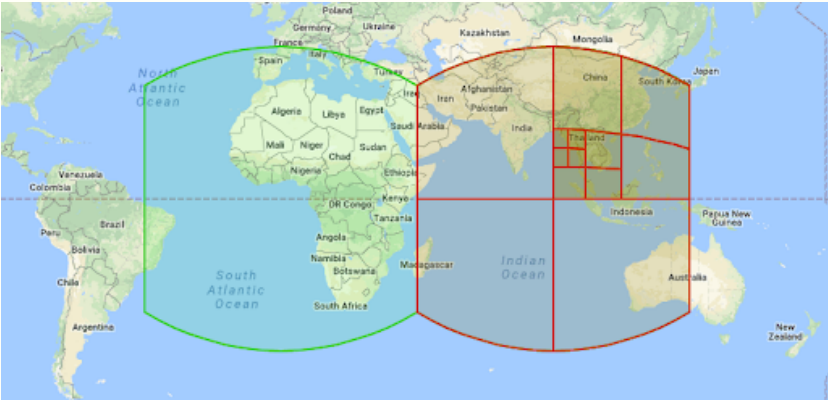


topic id — same shape



the top byte dominates XOR distance —
so “near in the keyspace” tracks “near on Earth.”
An area code, not a wall: it biases routing, it doesn’t partition.

192 CELLS COVER THE PLANET



A node roots the topics near it; a sparse region's root set simply spills to the nearest neighbors. Geography is a routing hint, not a border.

The mesh, and how a message travels

- A bridge bootstraps; the mesh carries.

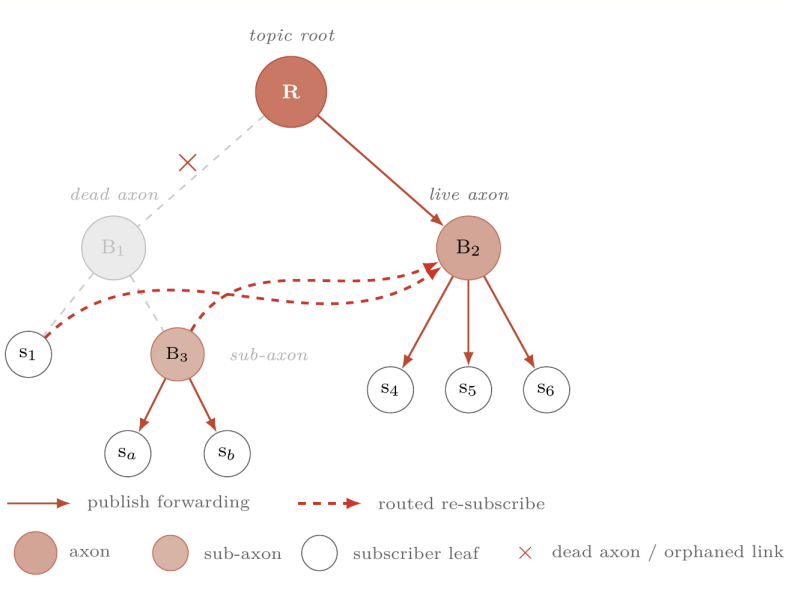
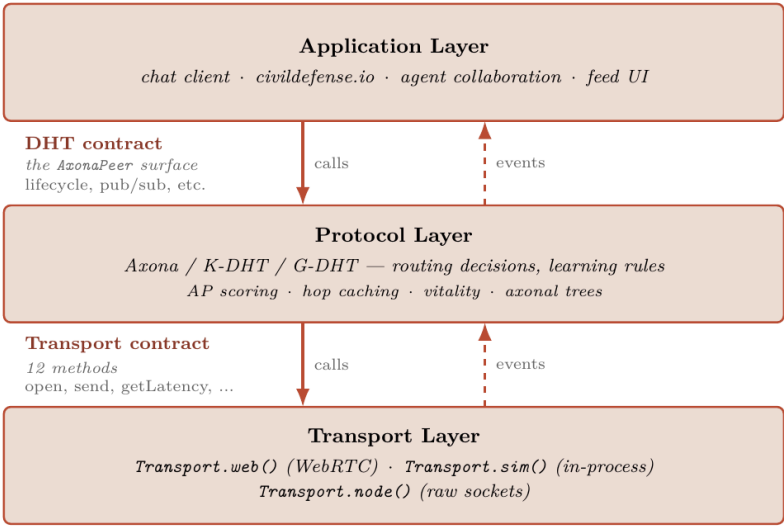
A WebSocket bridge introduces peers and relays signaling — a rendezvous, not a router. Peers form a WebRTC mesh and reach any id in a few hops via a learned routing table.

- Topics have a root set.

The R nodes closest to a topic id replicate it. A publish lands on the roots and fans out down a tree to the subscribers.

- It heals.

Gap-safe replay, root-to-root anti-entropy, and kill convergence keep replicas consistent — a missed message is backfilled, a retraction stays retracted.



The security model

- **Identity = keypair.**

The address is derived from the public key, and the transport handshake is mutually authenticated and channel-bound — a man-in-the-middle that swaps the media fingerprint fails the bind.

- **Signed, verified at ingress.**

A signed publish is checked against the publisher's key at the root, before it is cached or fanned out. Spoofed-signature spam dies at the edge.

- **You can only act for yourself.**

A subscribe or unsubscribe is honored only for the authenticated peer's own id — no subscribing a victim, no silencing one.

- **Bounded & content-addressed.**

A node only roots topics it is closest to; the message id is the hash of its content; a per-publisher sequence and TTL drop stale or replayed envelopes. Memory-hard proof-of-work prices a publish identity against Sybils.

NO TRUST SERVER

Every guarantee here is carried by the peers' own cryptography. No CA, no central authority sits behind any of it.

WHAT IT DOES *NOT* PROMISE

A kill is best-effort redaction, not a cryptographic un-send: a peer that already holds the bytes keeps them. And a medium no platform can censor is one no platform can moderate. Design with that in mind.

The API you actually call

- **Construct a peer.**

```
deriveIdentity() → webTransport() → new AxonaPeer() → peer.start().
```

- **Then publish and subscribe.**

```
peer.pub(topic, msg, {publisher}) and peer.sub(topic, handler, {publisher, since}).
```

That is the whole core loop.

- **The rest is on demand.**

```
unsub, pull (by id, or latest), kill (creator-only retract), host (serve a topic without consuming it), metrics, health.
```

WHERE A TOPIC LIVES

opts.publisher selects it:

value	the topic is...
omitted	your own feed
null	a public topic
hex id	someone's feed

A shared room uses a region-anchored publisher, so every peer in the region derives the same topic id.

Axona Minimal, in three steps

Connect — derive an identity, open the transport, build the peer:

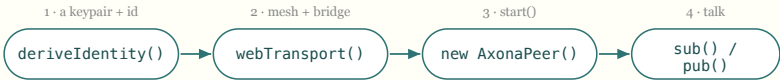
```
const id  = await deriveIdentity({ lat, lng });
const tr  = webTransport({ bridgeUrl: BRIDGE, identity: id });
const peer = new AxonaPeer({ domain, node, identity: id, transport: tr });
await tr.start(id.id); await peer.start();
```

Subscribe — the handler gets each envelope:

```
await peer.sub(topic, (env) => {
  if (env.deleted || seen.has(env.msgId)) return;
  render(env.message, env.signerPubkey);
}, { publisher: ANCHOR.publisher, since: 'all' });
```

Publish — render optimistically, dedup the echo:

```
const msgId = await peer.pub(topic, text, { publisher: ANCHOR.publisher });
seen.add(msgId);
```



...which is the whole of **Axona Minimal**:

topic

minimal/chat

message

type and press Send

Send

received

you · hello, mesh

≈ 60 lines, no framework.
Open it in two tabs and a
message crosses between them
over the live mesh.

demo.axona.net/apps/axona-minimal

That is the entire networking story. Everything else in the file is DOM glue.

Try it, then go deeper

• Run it.

demo.axona.net/apps/axona-minimal — open two tabs and watch a message cross between them. Add `?region=uswest` to land in another keyspace.

• Read it.

The Explainer (how the routing works), the Architecture note (kernel · transport · bridge · wire), and the API Reference for every exported symbol.

• Host it.

Run a relay (`axona-relay`) to carry your region's topics, or stand up your own bridge — the one piece you bootstrap from.

THREE LIVE DEMOS

demo.axona.net — Axona Minimal, the hello-world pub/sub example, and the S2 region globe.

THE KERNEL

axona-net/axona-protocol